

Tianhua Zou

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Renmin University of China

RESEARCH INTERESTS

My research focuses on sustainable development, bridging the welfare of disadvantaged populations with environmental policy and the energy transition.

I leverage large-scale household surveys and randomized controlled trials (RCTs), alongside causal inference powered by machine learning and LLMs. I am also an active user and advocate of AI agents in economic research.

EDUCATION

- **Renmin University of China** 2024.9-2027.6 (expected)
Ph.D. candidate in Applied Econ. Beijing, China
- **Stanford University** 2025.9-2026.8 (expected)
Visiting Student Researcher CA, USA
- **Renmin University of China** 2022.9 - 2024.6
M.S. in Applied Econ. Beijing, China
- **University of International Business and Economics** 2018.9 - 2022.6
B.S. in Finance Beijing, China

PUBLICATIONS

- [1] Lunyu Xie, Tianhua Zou, Joshua Linn, Haosheng Yan* (2024), **Can Building Subway Systems Improve Air Quality? New Evidence from Multiple Cities and Machine Learning**, *Environmental and Resource Economics*, 87(4), 1009–1044. (2024 Outstanding Publication in ERE)

WORKING PAPERS

- Cooling Inequality on a Hotter Planet, with [Lunyu Xie](#)
- How Local Discretion Shapes the Effects of a Central Mandate: Evidence from China's Clean Heating Policy, with [Lunyu Xie](#) and [Yuheng Zhao](#)

WORK IN PROGRESS

- A Second Pair of Hands: Intergenerational Co-parenting and the Effects of Parental Training on Early Childhood Development in Rural China, with [Scott Rozelle](#) and [Lei Wang](#)
- Housing Structure, Network Externalities, and Optimal Subsidy Dynamics, with [Mengjia Hu](#), [Joshua Linn](#), and [Lunyu Xie](#)
- Information Provision and Electric-Vehicle Adoption: A Randomized Field Experiment

EXPERIENCE

I am actively involved in the following labs:

- Sustainable Development and Poverty Alleviation Lab, School of Applied Economics, Renmin University of China (with Prof. [Lunyu Xie](#))
- China Residential Energy Consumption Survey (CRECS) Lab, Department of Energy Economics, Renmin University of China (led the 2023 round)
- [Rural Education Action Program \(REAP\)](#), Stanford Center on China's Economy and Institutions (SCCEI), Stanford University (with Prof. [Scott Rozelle](#))
- [Economics for Sustainability and Energy Transition \(eSET\)](#), Doerr School of Sustainability, Stanford University (with Prof. [Shanjun Li](#))

SELECTED AWARDS

- National scholarship for Postgraduates, Outstanding Graduates of Beijing

SELECTED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- 2025 Chinese Economists Society (CES) China Annual Conference, July 2025, Guangzhou.
- 9th Annual Workshop of the Sustainable Energy Transitions Initiative, June 2024, Online.
- 10th Xiangzhang Annual Conference, April 2024, Nanjing.
- 3rd National Development Youth Forum (NSD, Peking University), April 2021, Beijing.